Security Noir: Critical Designs for Security & Privacy

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In this paper, we investigate an alternative method for communicating the somewhat elusive security risks and privacy invasions of technology, the web, social networks, and other aspects of modern life. Specifically, we draw from the *critical design* movement popularized by Dunne and Raby in the 90s. In this project, we have conceptualized 10 new technological designs and described their use through short vignettes. These designs are imaginary but plausible technologies that illustrate a security or privacy risk through absurdity, satire, or humour.

ACM Reference Format:
Anonymous Author(s). 2026. Security Noir: Critical Designs for Security & Privacy. 1, 1 (February 2026), 6 pages. https://doi.org/10.1145/nnnnnnn.nnnnnnn

1 Introductory Remarks

Consider the following vignette from a collection of speculative artefacts:

> **Eleventh Finger.** Biometric authentication based on fingerprints is generally user-friendly and fast. Eleventh finger is a 3D printed rubber finger, customized with the user's fingerprint. You can put it on a keychain and use it on cold winter days when you do not want to remove your gloves. Alice lets her friend Bob borrow it when he stays at her house. It can also serve as a backup if the worst happens.

At face value, the design is a convenience-enabling accessory for biometric authentication; yet, the vignette also challenges common assumptions about fingerprints as secure, embodied identifiers. What happens when bodily identity is lent, misplaced, duplicated, or stolen? The scenario does not present a technical solution; instead, it invites reflection.

This mode of engagement is characteristic of critical design, which involves speculative artifacts and narratives that do not propose deployable products, but rather to provoke reflection and discussion. Critical design is commonly attributed to Dunne and Raby [2, 4] however it can be seen as a refinement of earlier movements in arts and design, beginning with the Italian radical design movement and extending through critical practice in HCI [12]. Consider the example provided in Table 1. In contrast to industrial design, the compass table is not oriented around problem-solving, nor the creation of solutions that are functional, useful, and pleasurable, nor is it meant for mass production. Rather it offers a subtle criticism by illustrating something—electromagnetic radiation—that typically goes unquestioned. It is designed to invoke a dilemma for the user, raising questions, challenging values, and stimulating debate. Critical design considers these goals to be the function (or 'para-function' [2]) of the concept.

Critical design has significant overlap with conceptual art, utilizing common methods, and has been disseminated through exhibitions and the art literature. However critical design works by showcasing things that are plausible, believable, and easy for the reader to situate, requiring design practice. Viewing critical design as art creates challenges. Consider the compass table (from Table 1) in the context of an art gallery exhibit—it is meant to illustrate electromagnatic radition in every day life, in one's home, in different positions and orientations within that home—all of this is lost

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Manuscript submitted to ACM

Table 1. An Example of Critical Design

Work	Vignette
Compass Table, A. Dunne F. Raby	"This table reminds you that electronic objects extend beyond their visible limits. The 25 compasses set into its surface twitch and spin when objects like mobile phones or laptop computers are placed on it. The twitching needles can be interpreted as being either sinister or charming, depending on the viewer's state of mind. When we designed the compass table, we wondered if a neat-freak might try to make all the needles line up, ignoring the architectural space of the room in favour of the Earth's magnetic field." Quoted from [4].

when it sits statically in a gallery. Should critical design be displayed in galleries, a vignette or film or narrative will often accompany the object to describe its context of use? Security and privacy risks are often intangible and invisible, making concepts difficult to communicate to everyday users. We saw a parallel to electromagnetic radiation in this regard, and considered if critical design could similarly aid in illuminating cybersecurity risks.

In this Provocations paper, we explore alternative methods of communicating elusive security and privacy risks through critical designs. We present ten speculative technological creation through short vignettes that leverage humour, satire, and exaggeration to render otherwise intangible concerns perceptible and reflectable. While the designs are exploratory, their grounding aligns with perspectives from usable privacy and security research that emphasize how users construct understandings of risk through informal channels, including entertainment media [6] and interpersonal stories (CITE Pfeffer et al., 2022), play a significant role in shaping users' awareness and interpretation of privacy and security risks. By presenting plausible but exaggerated artefacts embedded in narrative contexts, critical designs function as communicative probes that externalize otherwise invisible socio-technical tensions. We argue that if users already derive security lessons from mediated narratives, then critically constructed artefacts may serve a similar pedagogical role by acting as designed media that foreground overlooked vulnerabilities and provoke reconsideration of taken-for-granted technological assumptions. From this perspective, critical design is not merely artistic critique, but could function as a viable exploratory tool for risk communication.

1.1 Related Work

Critical Design for Security and Privacy. Much has been written on critical design and Malpass provides an excellent survey [12]. Since our focus is security and privacy, we only summarize the following concepts, situated within or close to critical design, since they deal with issues of privacy:

- **The Pillow.** Dunne and Gaver's design takes the form factor of a transparent pillow and plays radio signals it picks up from the technology of that time: *e.g.*, phones, pagers, and baby monitors [3]. It challenges users to consider how confidential these signals are.
- **Open Informant.** Matsumoto's app "searches your communications for National Security Agency trigger words and then sends text fragments containing these words to the badge worn by the user for public display" [12].
- **United Mirco-Kingdoms.** Dunne and Raby reimagine the UK as four 'supershires' where one is occupied by 'digitarians:' extreme technocrats ruled by algorithms in a state of total surveillance.

We are unaware of any attempt to build a systematic set of examples based on security or privacy, nor much attention to it from academic research papers, however critical design has been used in other areas of computer science. The uptake of critical design in HCI research is encouraged based on the anticipated value critical design will add to the

field [1]. Speculative design is another related concept that HCI researchers rely on. An example is to analyze and question the usage of a certain technology and the consequences of it in the near future [10]. Ludic design is also utilised to create designs that do not dictate a certain purpose or usage but rather leave the interpretation to users [7].

Alternative Pedagogy. Somewhat related to critical design, there are works on finding alternative ways (like design fiction [11], role playing game [13], science fiction and design fiction [15]) to explain tricky concepts not only in security but also in other fields like sensing technologies. Studying the metaphors used in CS education gives important insights about how students perceive certain concepts [9].

2 Initial Set of Designs

Crystal Avatars. Crystal avatars are created instantly but only gets better over time. At first, they are not recognizable and cannot be differentiated from other users, but as users browse the site, small details crystallize. Alice is happy to save time registering for the site and have a personal avatar, which automatically added a cat accessory after she spent a lunch hour reading about hairball treatments. However she grows uneasy about the "Woman, Life, Freedom" badge, a cause she believes in but only vocalizes discriminately.

Calm Watch. Calm Watch is a smart watch that tracks anxiety levels based on several biomarkers. When the anxiety level of the wearer crosses a threshold, a haptic vibration pulse prompts the user to look at the watch. From there, they can select a variety of calming techniques, including breathing exercises and guided meditation. Bob is nervous to talk to Alice and becomes flustered when his watch starts vibrating mid-conversation, just loud enough for Alice to hear it and notice his fidgeting with the watch.

Chatty. The latest software update for Alice's voice-activated home assistant Chatty adds machine learning to better infer Alice's commands, such as adding items to her shopping list and suggesting music she might like. It does not always know whether Alice is talking to it or not, so over time it picks up on pieces of Alice's life and has trouble unlearning them. Alice is startled but pleased when Chatty chimes in with the name of 'that actor who was in that thing' she was telling her friend about. She is bemused to find a specialized vinyl cleaning solution on her shopping list after she said Bob's records smells fishy.

Dynamic Laughtrack. Digital television content, such as sitcoms, encode laughtracks as a series of cues rather than an actual recording. Smart TVs listen and classify the viewer's level of laughter on a 10 point scale (with fine grain training over time). The TV adds laughter to the content in a sensitive and considerate manner, where the laughtrack is only marginally higher on the scale than the viewer's own laughter. This gently nudges the viewer to greater enjoyment of the program without bombarding her. It also mixes in actual past recordings of the viewer's own laughter to capitalize on emotional mirroring.

Eleventh Finger. Biometric authentication based on fingerprints is generally user-friendly and fast. Eleventh finger is a 3D printed rubber finger, customized with the user's fingerprint. You can put it on a keychain and use it on cold winter days when you do not want to remove your gloves. Alice lets her friend Bob borrow it when he stays at her house. It can also serve as a backup if the worst happens.

GOTTCHA. GOTTCHA is a human-detection system to protect online accounts being accessed by bots. It invokes the device camera to analyze if a live human is using the device. To protect against video replays or machine-generated video, it unexpectedly prompts the user with a randomly selected image and carefully measures their reaction to it. Micro-expressions are involuntary facial displays of emotion that are too fast to mimic artificially. GOTTCHA's image bank can provoke disgust, anger, fear, sadness, happiness, surprise or contempt. Over time, Alice stops visiting websites that use GOTTCHA because of its capricious tendency to mix in disturbing images.

No(i)sy elevator. Elevator music has never been regarded as elevating your mood. This is why employees will be happier riding the noisy elevator. When it recognizes a user, it spins up a selection from their most-played songs on major music streaming platforms. Alice finds hearing her favourite Miles Davis song grounds her at the start of each work day, while Bob and Carol, coincidently riding the elevator together, discover their shared love for 90s britpop. David is a bit more concerned about the profanity ridden banger that the nosy elevator plays for him and his boss.

Receiver plant. The receiver plant in the front yard of Alice records the information of the people that pass by. It is a greedy plant that needs to absorb enough bluetooth data to grow. Bob is singlehandedly responsible for its lustrous canopy from walking by Alice's house every day, mostly while checking his work emails on his phone. Perhaps the plant overstepped when it displayed, "you are 15 minutes late today, are you sure you can make it to work on time?"

ToS Fishing. ToS Fishing is a digital game where players earn points by hunting down excessive legalese on websites, including terms of service (ToS), privacy policies, and cookie policies. To play, users simply copy and paste the URL of the legalese. If the ToS has been seen before, the users are awarded points based on its word count. If it has not been seen before, it is reviewed by a human for validity and word count—and in this case, the user gets a finder's bonus. To mitigate people from launching custom websites, the game only accepts sites from the Alexis top million. Users display their aggregate score on a leaderboard with a profile showing their top catches (word count only, not the website), and can earn various badges for playing consistently.

Wifi Projector. Minimalist wifi routers have a single light indicator to show internet connectivity, such as a green light as opposed to red light. This understates the interesting and intriguing data flowing through the device as users browse the internet. By contrast, the wifi projector is a talkative router that projects visualizations onto the ceiling above where it is placed. Every website that pulls in scripts and cookies from other domains is displayed as a constellation of stars of various colours and sizes, which slowly fade away. While Alice's visit to dictionary.com is a beautiful galaxy, she is also perturbed by the number of ads and tracking companies surveilling her.

2.1 Methodology

We envision our research as a two-phase design study. The first phase was exploratory, with the goal of producing 10 designs (see below) to assess whether we can produce vignettes reliably, showcase different aspects of security and privacy without being repetitive, and craft narratives that are clear and memorable. The second phase (future work in §2.3) will develop a specific, reproducible method with clear steps and decisions rules.

For the first phase, authors (with cyber-security backgrounds) brainstormed possible inputs to a design, including (1) security and privacy concerns (*e.g.,* 'if you don't pay for the product, you are the product'), misconceptions (*e.g.,* 'nothing to hide'), or principles (*e.g.,* 'minimal disclosure') that could be the basis of a critique; (2) domains where users

might especially care about security or privacy (*e.g.,* health records or social networks); (3) a form factor for the new technology (*e.g.,* haptics or extended reality); and (4) a possible user responses (*e.g.,* amused or embarrassed). We then drew notes at random and held open-ended discussions about what the notes meant to us. Finally, we would try to envision technology, meant to be plausible in the near future (the reader can conceive why someone, somewhere might think it is a good idea) that provided a critique: *e.g.,* showing the darker side of convenience, risks that are normalized and overlooked, or ways a user might be betrayed by the technology. Each of our 10 designs was quite difficult to develop, each taking many hours of discussion and dozens of discarded ideas that we could not translate into designs.

2.2 Discussion

Vignettes. Critical designs are commonly described through vignettes, though they are occasionally built and displayed as physical artifacts. For example, Dunne and Raby's "Compass Table" in Table 1 (and the seven other objects in their *Placebo* project [4]), were built and given to individuals to use, followed by exit surveys capturing how the people felt about the objects. In this paper, we present our designs through short vignettes that describe both their form and use context. When successful, such descriptions allow readers to readily imagine these artefacts within their own lives and engage with them critically, resulting in its 'rhetorical use' [12] rather than practical deployment. These designs are intentionally transgressive, crafted to provoke emotional responses by invoking humour, satire, ridicule, poetry, playfulness, lewdness, appropriation, irreverence, or deliberate overcompensation.

Vignettes used in research contexts, in comparison, is defined as "short stories about hypothetical characters in specified circumstances, to whose situation the interviewee is invited to respond" [5] are established instruments in speculative design, design fiction, and scenario-based inquiry in HCI. In these contexts, short narratives depictions of hypothetical technologies or practices are used to surface assumptions, explore value tensions, and prompt reflection on possible futures without requiring the artefact itself to exist materially. Design fiction work in HCI, in particular, are not treated as empirical stimuli for behavioural measurement, but as structured prompts that enable participants to reason about situated technological futures, their consequences, tradeoffs, and social norms. Vignette-based methods in usable security research (e.g., [14], [8]) similarly construct narratives to investigate user expectations, decision-making processes, and ethical considerations surrounding emerging technologies when direct observation or deployment is infeasible, unsafe, or premature.

Usage Contexts. In this work, we propose vignettes as a methodological vehicle for communicating speculative artefacts rather than as experimental instruments intended to elicit measurable responses. The vignettes function as shareable analytic artefacts that others may appropriate for reflection, inquiry, and design exploration. This approach therefore aligns with established HCI practices in which narrative scenarios are used to probe socio-technical implications. However, it does not aim to produce generalizable behavioural data or predictive claims about user action. Instead, our objective is interpretive and exploratory—to expose assumptions, provoke critical reasoning, and broaden discourse around possible digital futures.

Beyond their role as speculative artefacts, we foresee several practical use cases of critical design vignettes for security and privacy. First, they may serve as reflective prompts in educational, participatory, or professional contexts, where speculative scenarios facilitate discussion of assumptions, values, and mental models surrounding security and privacy practices. Second, they may function as research instruments in future speculative design or vignette-based studies, where they can be adapted as stimuli to explore perceptions of risk, trust, or technological futures. Finally, we

envision their use as generative tools in design processes to inspire ideation, highlight overlooked attack vectors, or prompt reconsideration of design assumptions before technologies are implemented.

We therefore position 'Security Noir' (an homage to Dunne and Raby's term 'Design Noir' [4]) as a critical design approach for engaging with the often uncomfortable or hidden aspects of security and privacy technologies and their impacts on human experience. Methodologically, this approach takes the form of a lightweight, imaginable, and scalable medium that allows speculative artefacts to be encountered without technological implementation, while remaining grounded in established HCI traditions such as the use of vignettes in survey research, design fiction, and scenario-based studies. By embedding each design within a relatable narrative situation, the vignettes activate readers' existing mental models and experiences, supporting reflective engagement with security and privacy risks that are otherwise difficult to visualize or experience directly.

2.3 Future Work

We judged the first phase of our project to be a success. For the second phase, we plan on refining our methodology into a more precise, reproducible procedure for creating critical designs. Based on what worked in phase 1, we plan to start by developing a set of ideation cards that can be drawn in small combinations to spur creative thought. Using these cards, we will challenge ourselves to develop new designs. We will explore the use of generative AI tools in this process (note that the 10 designs in this paper were developed without the use of AI in any capacity). We plan on documenting the design process through auto-ethnography to identify the most effective practices, as well as difficulties (*i.e.,* coming up with topics related to security and privacy, attaining a level of plausibility, *etc.*). The methodology is intended to be transferable beyond security and privacy, enabling other researchers to develop critical designs in adjacent domains (*e.g.,* AI, algorithmic bias, deceptive patterns, *etc.*).

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